government—acknowledged that India now had a much-needed "friend at a critical juncture."[185]

In his memoirs, Kissinger described the treaty as a "bombshell."[186] At the time, however, he privately told Nixon he saw it as a response to the Sino-US rapprochement and also the Soviet Union's way of deterring India from making any rash moves related to the crisis.[187]

Senior Soviet policymakers were indeed urging Indian restraint.[188] Haksar, in turn, recommended that, in meeting with Foreign Minister Gromyko, Gandhi agree to consider what steps India and the Soviet Union could take together "to prevent a conflict." Nonetheless, it was crucial to assess what the two countries could do if a conflict broke out "so that India is enabled to emerge out of it successfully."[189] Indian policymakers continued to be concerned about Soviet reliability—especially now that the US option was no longer available. There were persistent questions about the status of the Sino-Soviet relationship, and disapproval of a potential Gromyko visit to Pakistan. Moreover, it rankled that Moscow was publicly underplaying the security provisions of the treaty.[190] Haksar suggested to Swaran Singh, the Indian foreign minister, that he make clear to his Soviet counterpart that the Indian people would expect help in the crisis.[191]

India had its insurance policy, but there continued to be uncertainty about whether China would indeed intervene in any potential conflict. In July, Gandhi wrote directly to Zhou, urging China to use its "undoubted influence" with Pakistan.[192] And Delhi, as Haksar put it, continued "to probe [Beijing's] intentions," and "refrained from making any statement which might even remotely irritate them."[193] A letter Haksar drafted for Gandhi to a member of parliament noted that India was "not insensitive" to the need for re-establishing relations with China and was trying to develop contacts with China through its embassies.[194] As a confidence-building measure in late August, Gandhi also approved approaching Beijing to establish a bilateral "wireless communication" link.[195] The Indian government was aware of Pakistani doubts about the extent of Chinese support, and wanted to limit that support.[196] The prime minister's general attitude toward China—as well as the exclusivity of the Indo-Soviet treaty—was evident in her suggestion that India approach China for a treaty as well. Haksar pointed out that this was not feasible at the time and would only anger the Soviet Union.[197]